Phishing: The Most Common Tactic

Phishing remains the most frequent social engineering tactic a bank SOC encounters.



1 What It Is

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Phishing is a fraudulent message, usually email, designed to trick someone into handing over credentials, clicking a malicious link, or opening a malicious attachment. It relies on impersonation and urgency rather than a technical exploit to get in the door.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The 2011 RSA SecurID Breach

Attackers sent two small groups of RSA employees an email titled "2011 Recruitment Plan," with an Excel attachment carrying a hidden Flash zero-day exploit.

One employee recovered the email from a junk folder and opened it anyway. That single click gave attackers a foothold that led to the theft of SecurID seed data.

The fallout cost RSA an estimated $66 million in remediation, and the stolen data was later used in an attempted follow-on attack against Lockheed Martin.

2 Why Volume Is So High

Why Volume Is So High

Phishing costs almost nothing to send at scale, and it only takes one person out of thousands to click. That math is why it remains the most common tactic a SOC sees, far ahead of more technically demanding attack types.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

FBI IC3, 2023 Internet Crime Report

Phishing and spoofing were the single most reported crime type to the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center in 2023, with 298,878 complaints filed.

298,878 complaints | **55,851 (next closest)**

That's roughly five times more reports than the second most common crime type, personal data breach — the clearest sign that attackers get more by sending more.

3 Evolving with AI

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Generative AI has removed the awkward grammar and formatting that used to make phishing emails easy to spot. Messages are now fluent, personalized, and harder to distinguish from legitimate correspondence, which raises the bar for detection.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

WormGPT, Reported July 2023

Security researchers identified a generative AI tool, advertised on underground forums, built specifically to write business email compromise and phishing messages on demand.

Unlike mainstream AI assistants, it had no guardrails against generating malicious content, and it produced fluent, convincing emails without the awkward grammar that once made phishing easier to spot by the writing alone.

CARRYING THIS FORWARD

Phishing wins on volume and economics, not sophistication — and AI is closing its last weakness.

What It Is → Why Volume Is High → Evolving with AI

From the 2011 RSA breach to today's AI-written lures, the pattern hasn't changed: one click is still all it takes.